7

TAKING BACK HINDUISM

If Hindutva is resisted by the vast majority of liberal Hindus, it is hardly paradoxical to suggest that Hinduism, India's ancient homegrown faith, can help strengthen Indianness in ways that the proponents of Hindutva have not understood. In one sense Hinduism is almost the ideal faith for the twenty-first century: a faith without apostasy, where there are no heretics to cast out because there has never been any such thing as a Hindu heresy. A faith that is eclectic and non-doctrinaire responds ideally to the incertitudes of a post-modern world.

So it was hard for a Hindu, proud of his faith's and his country's liberal traditions, not to be mortified, in 2015, when the visiting US President, Barack Obama, felt obliged to deliver a speech in New Delhi urging the government to live up to India's own values—and did it again in a post-Presidential visit in 2017.

'India will succeed so long as it is not split along the lines of religious faith,' Mr Obama said in 2015 in an implicit rebuke to the Hindutva brigades. The president was, of course, polite, couching his praise of religious diversity as a mutual strength of both India and the US, and speaking of his own challenges as a politician with the middle name of Hussein in a country increasingly hostile to Muslims. Many Obama critics in the US had alleged that he is a Muslim, not a Christian, the President acknowledged. 'There have been times when my faith has been questioned by people who don't know me…they said that I adhered to a different religion, as if that were somehow a bad thing,' he said.[1]

The president could hardly have been unaware, of course, that India's Hindutva-leaning prime minister had had a long track record of implying that belonging to a different religion than his own is indeed a bad thing —and that he depends for his political success on the support of people who have variously wanted all non-Hindus to convert 'back' to the mother faith or be driven out of the country. And he did it again on a visit to New Delhi in December 2017: 'A country shouldn't be divided into sectarian lines and that is something I have told Prime Minister